

AP Agent Business Case

Conservative numbers. No false precision.

Product	AP Agent OS
Tier	Professional
Version	1.0
Date	September 2026
Use	Implementation toolkit

Responsibility is earned.

What this model is for

To have an adult conversation with a CFO about capacity, cost and risk — not to print an IRR to two decimals.

Use the Excel workbook. This note explains the logic.

Inputs (you must supply)

- Monthly invoice volume
- AP headcount and fully loaded cost
- Manual-touch %
- Exception rate and average resolution minutes
- Duplicate rate (known)
- Late-payment fees / lost early-pay discounts (if you actually track them)
- Current processing cost (or allow the model to derive labour-only)
- AI / tool run-rate
- Implementation cost (internal days × rate + any vendor)
- Efficiency range on exception labour and manual-touch labour

Scenarios

Scenario	Exception labour reduction	Manual-touch labour reduction	Notes
Conservative	8%	3%	Shadow + Level 1 only, one or two agents
Base	18%	8%	Level 1–2 on triage, GR, validation
Upside	30%	15%	Requires data quality and change adoption; still no payment autonomy

These percentages are Evidence Room planning ranges, not forecasts. They are not Ardent statistics.

Outputs

- Baseline annual AP labour cost
- Capacity released (hours)
- Processing-cost change (directionally)
- Exception-cost change
- Estimated savings (labour + optional late-fee / discount lines)
- Incremental tool + implementation cost
- Payback (months) and ROI — labelled illustrative
- Sensitivity: volume ±20%, exception rate ±5pp, efficiency ±50% of scenario

Worked example (illustrative, not a case study)

A shared-services AP team processes 15,000 invoices/month.

- 12 FTE × \$75,000 fully loaded = \$900,000 labour
- Exception rate 22% → 3,300 exceptions/month
- 12 minutes each → 660 hours/month exception work (~4 FTE-equivalent)
- Conservative 8% exception-labour reduction → ~53 hours/month → ~\$33k/year at \$52/hour implied
- Tooling \$24k/year + \$40k implementation
- Conservative payback may exceed 24 months — which is an acceptable finding. The case then rests on control, cycle time and supplier experience, or you do not proceed.

Ardent 2025 average \$9.84 and Best-in-Class \$2.65 show why cost-per-invoice is a real executive metric. They do not prove your agents will close that gap.

What not to put on a slide

- “AI will save 40% in 90 days”
- Duplicate-payment savings you have never measured
- Vendor 99% accuracy as your benefit driver

This material is an implementation toolkit. It is not legal, tax, accounting, audit or investment advice. Agents do not authorise payments. Humans remain accountable. Statistics are cited in the Research Ledger.